

Memorandum

To: [professor]
From: Michael Hawthorne
Date: 06/21/2026
Subject: USA 250th Anniversary National Suitability

Background

July 4, 2026 marks the 250th anniversary of the founding of the United States of America. Many families will be taking to the streets to celebrate this momentous occasion. There are national celebrations to commemorate America250 in a multitude of locations across the contiguous United States. Some counties are more limited in resources and capability in housing and planning large, celebratory events like the America250 celebration.

In this project, we will determine, based on several geographic and statistical values, which counties may be best suited to host a large celebratory event like the America250 celebrations. This project will not try to predict where the actual America250 events will occur, but will rather seek to create a county suitability analysis based on population, July temperatures, major highway and thoroughfare access, and the availability of parks and parklands.

There are several assumptions when determining this likelihood: 1) The higher the population in a general location, the more likely there would be a 250th Anniversary celebratory event, 2) These events are more likely to occur in areas where there is more access to public spaces and parklands, 3) The events are more likely to occur in locations where there are major roadways and thoroughfare access, 4) The events are more likely to be in a location where July heat temperatures are just safe enough to accommodate for a large, celebratory gathering.

Methods

1. Unit of Analysis: County and county-equivalent areas across the contiguous United States, including Washington, D.C. County data can easily accommodate for the addition of park statistics, July temperature values, population data, and highway and transportation statistics. While a map showing all locations across the United States would be useful, this map will only highlight those areas where there are 250,000+ residents and in areas where park-access data is available to those individuals.

2. Data and Sources: County and population estimates were gathered from the U.S. Census Bureau's 2024 county population estimates. County boundaries were obtained from the U.S. Census Bureau. Park statistics were gathered from Public Land ParkServe data. This information was calculated based on park locations that are within a 10-minute walking distance to parklands. For transportation data, information was gathered from the National Highway System dataset from the Bureau of Transportation Statistics. A highway-density measure was created using the overall length of major highways divided by the county's total land area (expressed per 100 square kilometers of land). July heat and temperature information was obtained from PRISM 1991-2020 monthly climate normals.

3. Techniques: A majority of the project will use a Multi-Criteria Decision Analysis using population, access to parks, and highway density. July temperatures ranges use a reverse temperature suitability score. The ultimate calculation of these scores were weighted as: Population: 40%, Highway Density: 25%, Parklands: 25%, Temperature: 10%.

Limitations

1) The project is not intended to determine where America250 events are occurring but are rather trying to determine which counties are well positioned to host large-scale events such as the America250 celebrations. 2) The entire range of a county will not be completely suitable in all locations to house these events. 3) Highway density doesn't account for the means of transportation to these areas and does not account for influx and traffic patterns that could affect these roadways during these events. 4) Weather patterns are using historical data not real time weather information and models. 5) There are a number of different weights that could be used to change the overall effects and outcomes of this map.

Work Plan

- 1. Phase I: Data Preparation and Analysis [throughout semester]**
- 2. Phase II: Suitability creation, mapping, and results [due 06/21/26]**
- 3. Phase III: Storymaps preparation, presentation, and submission [due 06/28/26]**

Conclusion

The goal of the project is to produce a map showing a USA 250th Anniversary National Suitability Map showcasing the contiguous United States. The analysis uses county data, highway information, park accessibility, and July temperature conditions to determine the best counties suitable for large scale events similar to America250. The analysis of this project and upcoming StoryMap will provide more insight and provide a guided tour of some of the more suitable locations for some of these county locations.

Reference

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